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Off in a jiffy: Priyansh Arya and Prabhsimran Singh embody modern T20 intent, attacking from ball one and exploiting the PowerPlay ruthlessly, often looking to decide the contest within the first six overs. ^{AP}

par, even if they don't guarantee wins. Openers are expected to score at a minimum of 10 an over, and the rest of the batting order must maintain a similar tempo.

Teams are no longer building towards a late surge. The first six overs are now played with almost the same boundary-hitting intensity (26.53%) as the final four overs (24.03%). Since the inaugural season, there has been an overall +1.30 runs-per-over increase across the innings, with the most significant shift in the PowerPlay.

From 2008 to 2022, the first over had a run rate of 5.99, which has risen to 7.28 since the 2023 season, when the Impact Sub rule came into effect. Similarly, the second and third overs have seen increases of +2.10 and +1.96 runs.

While death-overs run rates remain the highest, the relative difference is now the smallest (for example, +0.81 in the 18th over). This suggests that hitting has always been strong at the end, but the 2023–2026 phase has extended that tempo into the start and middle overs. “I don't think there is a thing called finishers anymore. It's right from ball one; everyone is going at a rate of knots,” Chennai Super Kings coach Stephen Fleming had said earlier this season. “It's not about building up to the 16th over and then accelerating. Everyone is going hard from ball one. Run rates of 10, 11, 12 throughout are expected. You're not really getting the big peaks at the end; it's just a more aggressive approach to get 240.”

batting and go even harder,” PBKS assistant coach Brad Haddin said.

A look at the points table reflects which teams have embraced this approach of setting up, or even finishing, games early. Punjab, Royal Challengers Bengaluru, Sunrisers Hyderabad, and Rajasthan, the current top four, also boast the best returns from their top three batters, especially the openers.

For PBKS, Prabhsimran Singh and Priyansh Arya have scored at a strike rate of 205.55, followed by Royals openers Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi at 195.56. SRH's Abhishek Sharma and Travis

Head are at 189.25, while RCB's Virat Kohli and Phil Salt/Jacob Bethell have struck at 165.33.

Winning the PowerPlay isn't a guarantee, but it gives the batting side a significant advantage for the rest of the innings. DC's openers, for instance, have a higher strike rate (172.35) than RCB's. But Bengaluru's middle order has sustained the pressure and converted starts into results, while Capitals remain in the bottom half.

Is the finisher's role getting extinct?

The relentless attack from ball one has made 200-plus totals feel